Time and age

It can feel like time speeds up as we get older—a trip that felt like an eternity as a child passes quickly as an adult. Part of the reason for this is that our perception of time develops as we age. As infants, we live in the moment—we cry if we are not fed on time, but we are not aware of the passage of time. As toddlers, we are taught to become aware of time, and we learn how long it takes to perform everyday tasks, such as brushing our teeth. By the time we are six years old, we can estimate time, applying our knowledge of how long something takes to new situations.

Factors affecting time perception

As adults, we are more conscious of time, as we have responsibilities and schedules. These routines of moving from one event to the next can speed up our perception of time. However, there are also biological, proportional, and perceptual theories as to why time seems to speed up with age.

Metabolism

In a 24-hour period, a four-year-old's heart will have done 125 percent of the beats of an adult heart. Other biological markers, such as breathing, are also faster. This means children take in more information, so time appears to move slowly.

Proportional theory

As we age, time intervals constitute smaller fractions of our lives as a whole. For example, one year is 10 percent of a 10-year-old's life but only 2 percent of a 50-year-old's life.

Perceptual theory

The more information we absorb and process, the slower we perceive time to be. Children, who are experiencing many things for the first time, pay more attention to details that adults dismiss, which may stretch out time.

Pathways in the brain

As we age, the pathways in our brain grow more complex, so signals take longer to travel along them. This means older people view fewer images in the same amount of objective time, so time seems to pass more quickly.

HOW DO DRUGS AFFECT TIME PERCEPTION?

Dopamine is the main neurotransmitter involved in time processing. Some drugs, such as methamphetamines, activate dopamine receptors, speeding up the perception of time.

PERCEPTION OF TIME IS SUSPENDED WHEN WE ARE ASLEEP